



Memorable outing: Javokhir Sindarov produced a record-breaking run, finishing with 10/14 to win the event by a commanding 1.5-point margin over Anish Giri (left) and Fabiano Caruana.

mode in the latter half of the Candidates. There were no desperate pushes or unnecessary experiments as he steered games into comfortable draws to seal the biggest triumph of his career with a round to spare.

For the quietly confident Sindarov, this was a performance he always believed he was capable of.

"In my opinion, I'm one of the [most] talented players. But you can never predict that you will become the world champion, because it is very hard and you need to be lucky."

"I have always believed I can be one of the strongest players in the world and cross the 2800 rating. I'm very happy, but I'm not surprised to win this tournament because I always believed in myself," said Sindarov.

As Sindarov claimed the spotlight emphatically, the much-hyped Fabiano Caruana and Nakamura receded into the background.

The American GMs entered as favourites, backed by their experience against a comparatively inexperienced field.

But both Caruana and Nakamura flattered to deceive, withering under Sindarov's onslaught. It remains to be seen whether the two veterans have the energy and motivation to navigate another Candidates cycle in pursuit of a long-overdue World title.

India's sole hope in the open category, Praggnanandhaa, was left behind as well. The 20-year-old began with a confident opening-round win against Dutch GM Anish Giri but fell away from there, failing to win another game to finish seventh in the eight-man standings.

Sindarov will now square off against India's D. Gukesh for the world title in a 14-game match scheduled for later this year. Their clash has already created history, as it will be the youngest World Chess

Championship final of all time, with both players under 21 and Gukesh six months younger than his rival.

This will also be the second consecutive all-Asian World Championship final, signalling a shift in the balance of global chess.

With Gukesh's recent form in decline, Sindarov has already been labelled the favourite.

Meanwhile, Gukesh has announced that he will scale back his tournament commitments as he prepares for the title defence.

Sindarov, however, is wary of underestimating his opponent.

"I will play against one of the strongest players in the world, and we both have equal chances. Probably, because he played in a [World Championship] match, he has more experience, so a little bit more chance [for him]. Our playing strengths are very close. It will be a very interesting match," explained Sindarov.